

CAD FORUM

TECHNOLOGY AND DEBATE: AN ASSESSMENT

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"But what . . . is it good for?" (Engineer at the Advanced Computing Systems Divisions of IBM, 1968)

Wikipedia defines technology as the "the relationship that society has with its tools and crafts, and to what extent society can control its environment."³ However serviceable the definition, it is telling that I turned to a malleable website constructed through the open contributions to begin a discussion of technology and debate. The latest technological innovation to capture the debate community's attention is "open-source" web-based formats and their potential to "transform" debate. Much like the Wikipedia format, every debater potentially is the "author" of evidence and arguments; and, collectively are scouts, judge evaluators, theory and topic experts; turning traditional theories of pedagogy on their head. Contributors to this forum--each an active practitioner in some aspect of technological applications--address open-source and other issues facing debate that result from rapidly developing technological capabilities.

The forum grows out of a sense that debate is changing at a pace that excites but spawns a lingering feeling that in the not to distant future our activity may be unrecognizable. For example, there are real questions if tournament debate will survive when multiple ways to communicate are easier and cheaper than getting past airport security. We are familiar with struggles for budgets

³ <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Technology>

and recognition, yet find the technological shifts, at once exhilarating *and* disquieting.

A preview of this issue's forum took place at the 2006 National Communication Association's convention in San Antonio with a panel that addressed "technology and debate." Seven panelists shared their interpretations of the unfolding technological revolution in debate (some of whom are contributors in this issue). Their remarks essentially addressed two planes of technology's interface with the debate community: Defining and being defined by technology and applications for current debate practices.

The first level explores how technology forms or changes culture; who we are and what we are doing. At the panel, Karla Leeper, Baylor University, asked "Why are we engaging in the kinds of technologies as we are . . . how does that fit with the human part of competition?" The first three articles in this forum—O'Donnell, Woods et al., Schwartz-Dupry--provide thoughtful responses to "how does technology influence the community we want to be?"

The second level concerns practical aspects of technological applications for debate practice. Ursula Franklin, in her 1989 "Real World of Technology" lecture, defined technology as "the way we do things around here." At the NCA panel Brent Hinkle who manages *JoyOfTournament.com* commented on how technology has fundamentally changed the way tournaments are run, "compacting schedules, making them healthier via the magic of the computer." He talked about how small items like "self check-in" will further compress tournaments. The next four articles—Bruschke/Nielson, Bauschard, Snider, Morris--look at aspects of how technology fundamentally changes "what we do" in debate.

Organizing the essays in this manner is obviously arbitrary. Each essay addresses both choices about macro-managing technology and sensible implications. Readers will find useful commentary in each article that explore the "larger questions" and share ideas for daily practice.

The essays share common elements that frame the debate community's ongoing discussion. These include acknowledging

the “*inevitability*” of technology and an understandable reticence for predicting the future. Certainly, as a group, the contributors display a *confidence* that technologies hold the capacity to enlarge debate’s educational goals. They also share a recognition that students now learn differently, communicate differently; the result being that coaches and professional organizations need new ways of interfacing with debaters and the larger community.

An overarching theme that emerged in the NCA panel, and echoed in the current forum, addressed how the debate community should harness technologies to positively impact pedagogy. It remains unclear if debate is managing technology or technology is managing debate. Ross Smith, Wake Forest University, for example, noted during the panel that “the ability to rank judges has created a procedure of assigning judges that we use *because we can*. . . how does the ability to do something drive its use?”

Forum Preview

Tim O’Donnell takes a broad view and speaks to the certainty of technological change, the quasi-illiteracy of the debate community, and the underutilization of emerging technologies. He argues for “engagement” that broadens the debate community’s profile, not simply by learning the next application, but rather integrating with digital practitioners to facilitate more informed applications and decisions; bringing into play yet unanticipated possibilities.

Gordon Mitchell, lead a team of researchers to consider, both philosophically and directly, the effects of Digital Debate Archive (DDA)—open source technologies. They position their discussion of DDA in the currently unfolding platforms. Issues of architecture, pedagogy, competition, and how the DDA may change “external” debate organizations, even those not directly involved in the production and design of digital achieves, are discussed. The authors also speak to the generative qualities of open source and potential avenues for argument and forensics scholarship.

Rae Lynn Schwartz-DuPre moves beyond the localized tech deployment to consider how technology is transforming our sense

of community. She explores the ways underrepresented groups; women in particular, use community building to empower, finding discursive space in which they render debate participation manageable. Schwartz-Dupre's discussion reminds us that there are collateral benefits (and shortcomings) associated with all new technologies.

Jon Bruschke and Toni Nielson critique three emerging technical issues. Initially they explore the tension between governance and efficiencies, offering a realistic assessment of what the community "needs-to-decide" to keep the revolution in tournament management on track. They also explore the values (and costs) of opening judges to direct debater assessment and moving tournament tabulation on line.

Stefan Bauschard explores the potentially seismic shift in debater's use of the Internet, tracing the move from straightforward information retrieval to becoming generative participants. He describes the issues surrounding student interactions with experts and what "evidence" means when debaters bring their expertise to production and understanding of policy issues.

Alfred (Tuna) Snider argues that technology has advanced to the point that remote Internet debating is not only possible but a way to bring the US and world communities together. He provides practical tips to enact his vision, providing recommendations for how technical challenges, even for the under-funded and distanced, can be successfully negotiated. Snider grounds his discussion in debates he sponsors around the world.

Eric Morris' essay is principally practical, weighing the value of the growing practice of digitally recording in-round debates. He reports his experience with recording debates he judges, noting the pedagogical benefits--often transforming experiences. Morris also warns that debates are now "public property," with audiences potentially reaching far beyond peers and faculty. How this "exposure" may play out is explored.

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